The Midnight Visitor

The big idea

The Midnight Visitor by **Robert Arthur** is a short spy story in which **Ausable**, a fat and unglamorous secret agent, outwits an armed rival, **Max**, using nothing but his **presence of mind** and a made-up story about a **balcony**.

Characters

- **Ausable:** a secret agent in Paris; fat, speaks French and German with an American accent, does not look like a spy at all — but is extremely **quick-witted** and calm.
- **Fowler:** a young, romantic **writer** who expected a thrilling spy with mysterious women; he is disappointed by Ausable — until he sees him in action.
- **Max:** a rival agent, slender, with a pointed nose, who holds a **pistol**; clever but outwitted.
- **Henri:** the waiter who brings the drink Ausable had ordered.

Summary

1. Ausable takes Fowler to his room on the **sixth (top) floor** of a gloomy French hotel. He tells him he is expecting an important report about some **new missiles**.
2. When they enter, they find **Max** already inside, holding a pistol. He has come for the report.
3. Ausable stays calm. He grumbles that this is the second time someone has got into his room through the **balcony beneath the window**, and that he had complained to the management about it.

4. He adds that he has reported the matter to the **police** and they will be sending someone to check. Soon there is a **knock** at the door.
5. Max, fearing the police, backs to the window and swings himself out to hide on the "balcony" until they leave. He **screams** as he falls — there was **no balcony**.
6. The door opens: it is **Henri, the waiter**, bringing the drink Ausable had ordered.

AUSABLE'S TRICK

He invents two things on the spot: a **balcony** below the window and **police** coming to check up. When the waiter knocks, Max believes the police have arrived and jumps onto the imaginary balcony.

AUSABLE WAS NOT A TYPICAL HERO

He is fat and unromantic; his weapon is **intelligence**, not gun-fights. That contrast with Fowler's expectations is a key point.

Themes and value points

- **Presence of mind** and calmness can defeat brute force.
- **Appearances are deceptive** — don't judge by looks.
- Intelligence is more powerful than weapons.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How was Ausable different from the popular image of a secret agent? How did Ausable get rid of Max? Who was at the door? Was Fowler impressed in the end?

Quick recap

- Robert Arthur; Ausable (fat secret agent), Fowler (writer), Max (rival with pistol), Henri (waiter).
- Sixth floor; report about missiles.
- Imaginary balcony + "police" knock → Max jumps → it was the waiter.

Practice questions

1. How was Ausable different from the image of a secret agent?
   (a) He was tall and handsome (b) He was fat and did not look like a spy (c) He carried many weapons (d) He had a beautiful assistant
2. Who was Fowler?
   (a) A secret agent (b) A policeman (c) A young writer (d) The hotel manager
3. What was Max looking for?
   (a) Money (b) Diamonds (c) A key (d) A report about new missiles
4. What did Ausable invent to trick Max?
   (a) A secret door (b) A hidden gun (c) A balcony beneath the window (d) A trap under the carpet
5. Who knocked at the door?
   (a) The police (b) Another spy (c) Henri the waiter (d) Fowler's friend
6. On which floor was Ausable's room?
   (a) Ground floor (b) Second floor (c) Sixth floor (d) Tenth floor
7. How did Ausable get rid of Max?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. d 4. c 5. c 6. c 7. see notes